

Puja Majumder

Before You Visit The Baby

The Real-Talk Guide for New Parents &
Well-Meaning Visitors in Indian Families

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Parents

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Disclaimer: This book is written from lived experience
and is not a substitute for medical advice. Always
consult your pediatrician for decisions about your
baby's health.

Dedication

This is for my partner, who supported me throughout. He said that if you are starting this journey, make sure you reach the finish line.

This is for my mother, who went through a lot to give birth to me. Few decades back, the medical facilities were not as top notch as they are now. With extreme pain, our mothers gave birth to us and our siblings. We are so lucky to have an option of Epidural, but few decades back this was unthinkable. This is to all the mothers and their villages who have ever raised a child

For every new mother who smiled politely, while silently wishing everyone would just go home.

And for every visitor who genuinely wanted to help.

This one is for both of you.

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Note from the Author

Hey there.

I'm a mother of two. And if there is one thing I have learned across two pregnancies, two postpartum recoveries, two rounds of visitors, and thousands of opinions I never asked for - it is this: people genuinely want to help. They really, truly do. But wanting to help and actually helping are two very different things. And nobody tells them the difference.

This book was born out of those awkward moments that every new parent knows too well. The aunty who came straight from a public event and asked to hold my newborn. The relative who arrived with a cough and said "it is just allergies". The relative who posted my baby's photo on Instagram before I was ready. The family member who took one look at my baby and said something about her skin colour that I will never be able to unhear.

Nobody meant harm. I know that. I have always known that. But a new mother is running on zero sleep, stitches in places she cannot talk about, hormones that make everything feel enormous, and a love for this tiny human that is so fierce it terrifies her. In that state, words land differently. Visits feel longer. Overstaying feels like a crisis. A comment that would roll off in any other season of life can genuinely break something inside her.

So I wrote this guide. Because somebody had to.

This is not a medical textbook. I am not a doctor, or a lactation consultant, or a child psychologist. I am a mother of two who has been in that bed, in that room, in that impossible position of wanting to say "please leave" but not being able to find the words. I am writing this from lived experience, from two postpartum recoveries. I am writing this from my heart.

This book is for new parents who want to share it with everyone coming to visit. It is for visitors - grandparents, relatives, friends, colleagues - who love the family enough to read it first. It is for partners who need to understand what their role is during this season. And it is for the elder sibling, who nobody is talking about but who is quietly having the hardest time of all.

This guide is meant to be shared. Think of it as the briefing document before anyone walks through that door. One copy. One very informed village.

I wrote this guide so that as a mother, you know that you are not alone. We've been there.

And I hope this lifts you - even if, just a little. :)

With Love,

Puja Majumder, A Mama who's been there. Twice.

Why This Guide Exists

In Indian families, a new baby is not just an addition to the family. Its an event, its a community event. The entire mohalla wants in. The extended family group chat is on fire. The neighbours have already asked three times when they can visit. Everyone is excited. Everyone is full of love. Everyone wants to be there.

And that is beautiful. Genuinely, truly beautiful.

But here is what nobody says out loud: the first days and weeks after birth are also the most physically and emotionally demanding period of a woman's life. Labour and delivery are not the end of the hard part. In many ways, they are the beginning.

When your relatives are planning their visit, these are the things your body is actually dealing with:

What New Moms Are Dealing With	Why It Matters for Visitors
Sleep deprivation - newborns wake almost every 2 hours	A long visit = a missed sleep window she cannot get back
Post - birth recovery - stitches, pain, soreness	She may not have the energy or courage to say 'please leave'
Breastfeeding establishment (first 4 weeks are critical)	Interruptions and stress directly affect milk supply

Hormonal fluctuations - up to 80% of new moms experience baby blues	Emotions are heightened; words and situations land very differently
Newborn immunity is near zero	Every single visitor is a potential carrier of illness
Physical healing - C - section recovery, perineal tears	Standing, sitting, walking, and hosting are genuinely painful activities

When you read that table, something shifts. Suddenly a 90 - minute visit to "just come and see the baby" looks very different. Suddenly bringing the whole family - all seven of them - at the same time looks very different. Suddenly the comment about how the baby's skin colour is or how the mother "still looks pregnant" lands exactly as hard as it deserves to.

This guide is not about keeping people away. Indian families thrive on togetherness. The village is real, and it matters. The food that relatives bring, the hands that hold the baby so mama can sleep, the grandmother who sits quietly and just listens - these things are everything.

This guide is about making sure that love is delivered well. That the visit lifts the family instead of depleting them. That visitors leave having genuinely helped, and parents feel supported rather than overwhelmed.

That is all this is. Love, delivered with awareness.

A little awareness from visitors goes a very, very long way."

Chapter 1: Hospital Visits



Hospital Visits: The Golden Rules

When I think about it now, the hospital is actually the ideal place to meet a newborn for the first time. Here is why: there are nurses, there are timelines, there is a natural time limit built into the environment, and there is always a medical reason to end the visit. The hospital does the work that you would otherwise have to do yourself.

Use this window wisely. Because once everyone has met the baby at the hospital, you have far more power to manage home visits in the weeks that follow.

Visitor's Checklist:

Before You Even Leave Your House

- Always call or message before coming. Never, ever show up unannounced at the hospital.
- Confirm the timing with the partner, not just the family WhatsApp group.
- If you have even a slight cold, a cough, or a temperature - stay home. Reschedule. No exceptions.
- Check whether the hospital has visitor restrictions - many do, especially for newborn wards.

When You Arrive at the Hospital

- Keep the group small. Maximum two visitors in the room at one time. If more people came, take turns and wait outside.
- The first thing you say when you walk in is: 'How are you doing?' - to the mother. Not 'Where is the baby?' To. The. Mother.
- Do not sit on the hospital bed. Do not touch or move any equipment. Do not rearrange anything.
- Sanitise your hands the moment you arrive - before you hug anyone, before you touch anything.

About the Baby

- If the baby is sleeping - let the baby sleep. Do not ask to hold them. Do not wake them for a photo.
- Keep your voice soft and low. No loud exclamations, no shrieking 'oh my GOD she is so cute' the moment you walk in.
- Wait to be invited to hold the baby. Do not reach for them.
- Never kiss the baby - not on the face, not on the forehead, not anywhere. This is a non - negotiable rule.

Leaving

- Keep the visit to 20-30 minutes. You are not there to settle in. You are there to meet the baby, see that the family is okay, and leave.
- Do not linger. When you say you are leaving, leave.
- Ask if there is anything you can bring on your next visit - groceries, food, anything practical.

Mama's Hot Take

Meeting the newborn at the hospital is genuinely the best - case scenario. There is support staff around, it is easier to manage the visit, and the environment itself creates a natural time limit. I always encouraged relatives to visit at the hospital rather than waiting to descend on our home in the first few weeks. It made everything so much more manageable.

Chapter 2: Home Visits



Home Visits: Timing, Duration & Sanity

The home is a different environment from the hospital. There are no nurses. There is no built - in time limit. There is no medical professional to use as an excuse. And the new mother is now also responsible for hosting - even when she is still bleeding, even when she has not slept, even when the last thing in the world she wants is to make tea for someone who has come to hold the baby for an hour.

This is why timing and duration matter so much when it comes to home visits. Here is an honest, week - by - week breakdown:

Visit Window	What is Happening	What is Recommended
Day (1-7) First week	Mom is exhausted, bleeding, possibly in pain. Baby is feeding every 2 hours. Nothing is established	Hospital only. No home visits
Week 2-3	Routine is still not set. Baby's weight is being monitored. Mom needs rest, not company	Close family only. Visits under 30 minutes

Week 4 onwards	Routine is beginning to form. Mom may be ready for more controlled visits	Yes - but always with advance notice
6 weeks+	Most moms begin to feel more settled around this time	Ideal visit window for extended family

Home Visit Duration Rules

- Keep visits to 30-40 minutes maximum for the first two months.
- Watch the mother's body language constantly. Yawning, quietness, glancing toward the bedroom - these all mean it is time to go.
- Do not come during feeding time. Always ask the parents what time works best.
- Avoid evening visits. The window between 5 PM and 9 PM is typically the baby's fussiest period - what parents call the 'witching hour.' This is not a good time for guests.
- If you come, offer to help. Play with the older sibling. Bring food. Do the dishes. Be useful.
- Never show up unannounced. Ever.

How to End a Visit Gracefully - For Visitors

- Set a mental timer when you arrive. When 30 minutes have passed, begin wrapping up.
- Say: 'We will head out now so you can rest.' And then actually head out.
- Do not wait to be asked to leave. If you are watching for signs that you should go, you have already stayed too long.")

Mama's Hot Take

For both my babies, mornings were chaotic - feeds, bath, breakfast for the elder one. The sweet spot for us was 12 PM to 4 PM. The morning rush was over and the evening fuss had not started yet. That window was genuinely welcome. Please - always confirm with the parents the day before.

Chapter 3: The Visitor Body

Language Bible



The Visitor Body Language Bible

You might not realise it, but your body language communicates everything the moment you walk into a home with a newborn. Before you have said a word, the new mother has already assessed: Are you calm? Are you going to reach for the baby? Are you going to settle in for the afternoon? Are you going to make things harder or easier?

Here is a complete guide to what to do - and more importantly, what not to do - from the moment you arrive.

DO This	AVOID This
Speak softly. Use a calm, low voice from the moment you enter	Do NOT coo loudly, shriek, or make sudden exclamations
Sit down and sanitise before you do anything else	Do NOT walk in and immediately reach for the baby
Wait to be invited to hold the baby	Do NOT ask 'Can I hold the baby?' the moment you arrive
If someone is already holding the baby, sit and admire from where you are	Do NOT form a 'holding queue.' The baby is not a prop
Always wash or sanitise hands before touching the baby	Do NOT touch the baby's face, hands, or mouth without sanitising

Ask before you take photos	Do NOT snap photos and post online without asking both parents
Keep mobile phones away from the baby's face	Screens can overstimulate newborn eyes. Keep them away
If the baby starts crying in your arms, hand them back immediately	Do NOT try to 'handle it yourself' - return baby to the parent at once
Leave quietly without making the departure dramatic	Do NOT ask for 'one more hold' on the way out

The NEVER List - Non - Negotiable Rules

These are not guidelines. These are absolute rules. There are no exceptions, no 'just this once,' no 'but I am the grandmother.' These apply to everyone, every time.

- Never kiss the baby - not on the cheek, not on the forehead, not on the hands. No exceptions.
- Never wake a sleeping baby for a photo. A sleeping baby is a gift from the universe to exhausted parents. Do not unwrap that gift.
- Never breathe directly into the baby's face. Keep a respectful distance.
- Never bring a sick child to visit a newborn. If your own children have any illness, they stay home.

- Never put your fingers near the baby's mouth. Newborns put their hands in their mouths. Your hands are a direct pathway for germs.

Mama's Hot Take

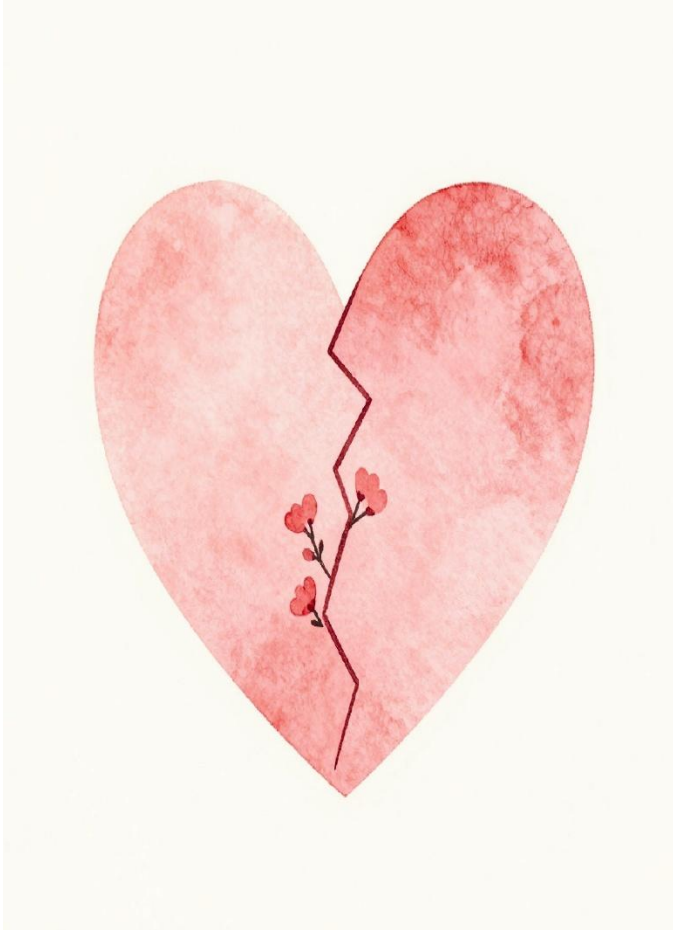
The moment a visitor walked in and immediately reached for the baby - before saying hello, before sitting down, before asking how I was - I felt invisible.

The baby matters. I know they have come to see the baby.

But asking about me, acknowledging me felt very good and it lifted me up.

A mother has just delivered that baby. Ask about her too, and not as an afterthought. It costs nothing and it means everything.

Chapter 4: Hall of Shame



The 'What NOT to Say' Hall of Shame

Words land very differently when you are sleep - deprived, hormonally charged, physically recovering, and running on love and anxiety in equal measure. Things that would bounce off in any other season of life can genuinely break something in a new mother.

The comments below are said every single day in Indian households. They are said with love. They are said with familiarity. They are said without any intention of harm. And they land like knives anyway.

Here they are - and here is why they hurt:

The Comment	Why It Hurts
Oh, she is so dark He looks like he needs some sun	Comments on a newborn's skin colour are inappropriate, hurtful, and completely unnecessary. Somethings cannot be unheard once you hear them Given a choice, be kind instead of being right
Is she small? She seems underweight	The baby's weight is the paediatrician's job - not yours. The mother is already anxious about every gram. Do not add to it
Arey, a girl again? or any gender disappointment comment	Gender disappointment commentary has absolutely no place in a newborn's welcome. None

You look so tired. You have not recovered yet	She just had a baby. Of course she is tired. Say she looks amazing instead. Say she is doing an incredible job
Are you breastfeeding? You should try harder	Feeding choices are deeply personal and often medical. This is none of your business. None of it
My baby never cried this much	Comparison is the thief of joy and sanity. Every baby is different. Every mother is different. Stop comparing
When are you going back to work?	She just had a baby. She does not need a timeline. She needs support
You still look pregnant	Her body just did something extraordinary. Keep your observations about it to yourself

What TO say instead: 'You are doing amazingly well.' | 'The baby is absolutely beautiful.' | 'Is there anything I can do to help?' | 'I am so proud of you.' | 'You look incredible.'

These phrases cost nothing. They do everything. Choose them every time."

Chapter 5: What To Say Instead



What To Say Instead

The Hall of Shame chapter told you what not to say. This one tells you what to say instead. Because the right words at the right moment can be the difference between a visit that drains a new mother and one that genuinely lifts her.

Be kind. Walk in wanting to make her feel seen, supported, and celebrated - and the right words will follow.

The Word Swap Guide

X Instead of saying...	✓ Say this instead...
You look so tired	You are doing an incredible job
She is so dark	She is absolutely beautiful
He seems underweight	He looks so healthy and loved
Arey, a girl again?	She is so lucky to have you as her parents
Are you breastfeeding?	Is there anything I can bring you to eat?
My baby never cried this much	Every baby is different - you know yours best
You haven't recovered yet?	Take all the time you need - you just did something extraordinary
Can I hold the baby? (on arrival)	I'm happy just being here - whatever you need

When are you going back to work?	How are YOU feeling today - really?
This is how we did it before	What does your doctor say?
You look different since the baby	You are glowing - motherhood suits you
You're the big one now, be responsible	Being a big sibling is the most special thing in the world

The Golden Phrases - Use These Freely

What to Say to the Mother

- You are doing amazingly well.
- The baby is absolutely beautiful.
- Is there anything I can do to help?
- I am so proud of you.
- I brought food - where shall I put it?
- I will see myself out - you rest.
- Thank you for letting me visit.
- Take all the time you need.

What to Say to the Partner

- You are a great dad / partner.
- How are YOU holding up?
- You are both doing so well.
- Let me know if you need anything at all.

What to Say to the Elder Sibling

- Wow - you are such a wonderful big brother / sister.
- I brought something special just for you.
- Can you show me around and introduce me to the baby?
- Tell me - what do YOU think of the baby?
- Being a big sibling is the most important job in the world.

And when you do not know what to say? Sometimes the most powerful thing you can do is simply sit quietly, be present, and let her know she is not alone. You do not need the perfect words. You just need to show up with love.

Chapter 6: Gifting Right



Gifting Right: Including the Elder One

Gifts are lovely. A homemade meal, a box of sweets, a thoughtful onesie - gestures of love matter enormously to a new family. But sometimes, all the attention and gifts suddenly shift to the newborn - leaving an older sibling confused, hurt, and often acting out. And leaving the new mother with seventeen baby outfits and nothing to eat for dinner.

This chapter is about gifting well. About gifts that actually help. About gifts that leave the whole family - not just the baby - feeling seen and loved.

Gift Type	Best For	What to Avoid
Practical gifts for the baby: onesies (Size 0-3 months or 3-6 months), wipes, muslin cloths etc	The parents	Buying Newborn size - babies outgrow it in days
Homemade meals, snacks, fruit baskets, healthy food for mama	The new mother - specifically	Strong-smelling foods, foods she is allergic to
A gift for the older child: book, puzzle, small toy, dry fruit basket with their name on it	The sibling	Anything that makes them feel forgotten or left out

Shopping vouchers or gift cards	Both parents	Generic items they already have plenty of
Your time - offer to do errands, folding clothes, playing with the elder one	The whole family	Sitting and being an additional guest to host
A self - care kit for the mother: moisturiser, a book, herbal tea, a foot spa	The mother personally	Gifts only for the baby when mama needs care too

The Elder One Rule

If you are getting a gift for the newborn, please get something for the older child too. It does not need to be big. It does not need to be expensive. A book. A small toy. A puzzle. The message it sends is not about the object. The message is: you are still seen. You are still loved. You are still important.

That message is everything to a child who is suddenly sharing the spotlight with a tiny, demanding newcomer who cries constantly and gets all the attention.

The Food Rule

If you are visiting and you want to bring something - bring food for the mother. Not more baby gifts. Food.

Homemade daal and rice. Rotis. A fruit basket. A box of dry fruits. A container of homemade halwa. The new mother is doing the physical work of growing another human being through breastfeeding, recovering from birth, and surviving on no sleep. She needs to eat well, and the last thing she has energy for is cooking.

Bring food. It will be received with more gratitude than you can imagine.

Mama's Hot Take

One of my relative showered my elder one with so many gifts. He was so happy. I was moved and I was so so grateful that he thought about the elder one too.

Even when I was buying things, I would buy for both of them. I remember I bought a Holi onesie and a Holi t-shirt for them. I thought "great, I have covered for both of them". But I was surprised when my son said – why both the apparel do not have the same design; D

So, yes there can still be questions but the bare minimum is to make sure I have got something for both my kids.

On a side note, prepping our elder one for the arrival of little one has been a good decision. It was not a surprise to him. He gradually understood that there is another person joining the family.

I have observed that when I explained it to him, he actually listened and tried to understand. Of course,

he had a lot of questions and they were being asked on repeat. So, we were explaining the same thing many times a day. I think its definitely worth it.

Prep the elder one so that they become aware of the process. This way, they do not feel left out.

Chapter 7: Social Media & Photos



Social Media & Photos: Read Before You Post

This chapter is the one I feel most passionately about. Because nothing - nothing - is more violating to me as a new mother than seeing my newborn's photo posted online when I was not ready to share it with the world. When I had not yet decided what I wanted to share, how I wanted to share it, or whether I wanted to share it at all.

To parents who are perfectly comfortable with others sharing photos - you can skip this chapter. This one is for parents like me.

The Non - Negotiable Rules of Photos

- Never post a photo of the newborn online without explicit consent from both parents. Not one parent. Both.
- Taking a photo on your phone does not mean you have permission to post it. These are two completely separate actions.
- Do not post "just to share the joy" The parents will share when they are ready. On their terms. In their time.
- Do not post to increase your own social media engagement using someone else's newborn. This is not about you.
- Do not tag the location of the parents.

Before You Take Any Photos

- Ask. Simply ask. 'Is it okay if I take a photo?' takes four seconds and respects everything.
- Ask before every visit, not just the first one. Comfort levels change. Ask each time.
- If you are unsure - do not take the photo. The opportunity to ask is always there.

About Screen Time Near the Baby

- Keep mobile phones away from the baby's face. The light and screens can overstimulate newborn eyes. And mobile phones carry more germs than you realise.
- The flash on a camera is not appropriate to use near a newborn. Avoid it entirely.
- When you are holding the baby, put your phone away. Be present.

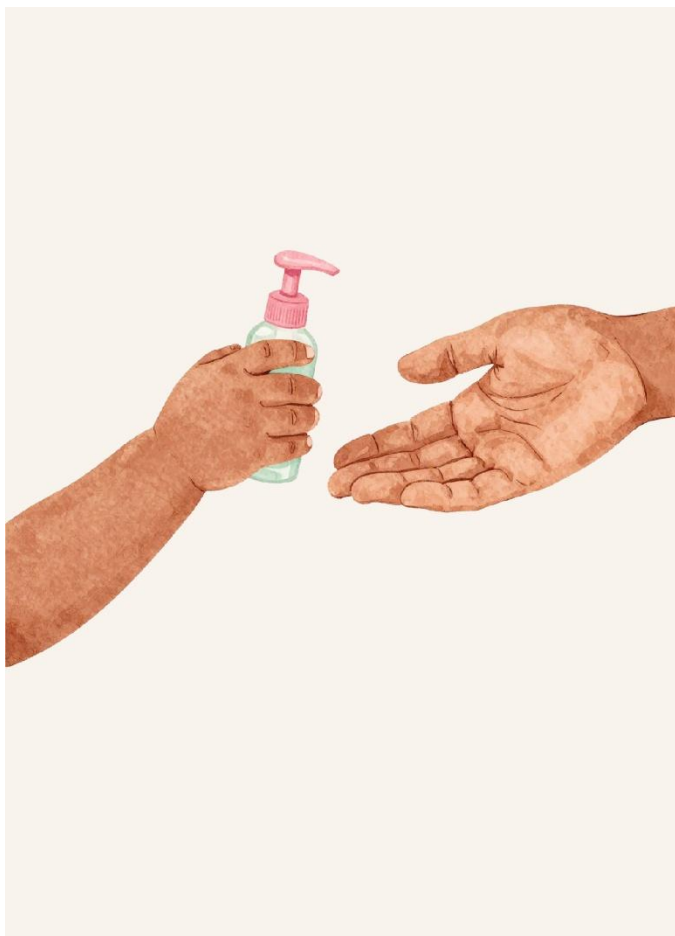
The parents are going through an incredibly intimate, raw, exhausting time. The decision of what to share, when to share, and how to share their child's image belongs entirely to them. Please respect that. Full stop.

Mama's Hot Take

I was not ready to share my baby's face online for several weeks. And a relative posted a photo before I was ready to share that image. I cannot tell you how that felt. Please ask. Please always ask.

Next time onwards, I made sure to mention “Please do not post it online”

Chapter 8: Hygiene Rules



Hygiene Rules: No, They Are Not Optional

A newborn's immune system is not fully developed initially. In those first weeks, the baby has very little ability to fight off infection. Every person who walks through that door is a potential carrier of illness - and what is a minor inconvenience for an adult can be genuinely dangerous for a newborn.

These rules are non - negotiable. They come from love, not from paranoia. They are not about being difficult or overcautious. They are about keeping a tiny, vulnerable human being safe.

The Rule	Why It Matters
Stay home if you have any cold, cough, fever, or illness - even a mild one	RSV, flu, and common cold viruses can be very dangerous for newborns
Wear freshly washed clothes when visiting a newborn	Clothing carries bacteria, allergens, and infection from outside environments
Always wash hands with soap for at least 20 seconds before touching the baby	Hand hygiene significantly reduces the risk of infant infection
Use hand sanitiser (60%+ alcohol) if soap and water is not immediately available	Sanitiser at the door is the first line of defence
Do not touch the baby's hands or face	Newborns put their hands in their mouths -

	your hands are a direct pathway for germs
Never ever kiss the newborn - not on face, forehead, ears, or anywhere	Newborns catch cold easily from viruses, and can quickly escalate into more serious illnesses.
Do not bring your own young children if they have any illness	Children carry viruses that can be passed easily to newborns
Skip the perfume and cologne before visiting	Strong fragrances can irritate a newborn's sensitive respiratory system

A Note on Kissing the Baby

I want to address this one separately because it comes up constantly and because people genuinely do not understand the risk. You can be carrying a virus and feel completely fine. Adults often shed viruses like RSV and cold viruses without any symptoms at all. But when that same virus reaches a newborn whose immune system is still developing, it can escalate rapidly into something far more serious. A 'just a little peck on the cheek' is not a little thing when it comes to a newborn. It is a serious health risk. Please, please do not kiss the baby. Not on the face. Not on the forehead. Not on the hands. Not anywhere.

Mama's Hot Take

We gave our elder one the job of offering sanitiser to every single person who came close to the baby. They took that job with enormous seriousness and pride. It solved two problems at once: the hygiene issue and the 'left out elder sibling' issue. He felt part of it and did the duty with full involvement. Highly recommend.

Chapter 9: Managing the In - Laws



Managing the In - Laws: They Mean Well. They Really Do.

In Indian families, the in - laws do not just visit after the baby arrives. They arrive. With bags. With opinions. With a very specific way of swaddling that they are absolutely certain is the only correct way. With recipes for the mother's diet that were passed down for generations. With beliefs about sleep, feeding, massage, and every other aspect of newborn care that may or may not align with what the paediatrician said.

This chapter is not about choosing sides. This is not a chapter that pits the new mother against the in - laws. This is about making sure that everyone in that house - the new mother, the new father, and the new grandparents - comes out of those first weeks still loving each other.

The In - Law Paradox

Here is the truth: in - laws are often the greatest source of practical support in the postpartum period. They cook. They clean. They hold the baby so the mother can rest. They bring love and experience and continuity. These things are invaluable.

And in - laws are also sometimes the greatest source of stress. Conflicting advice. Strong opinions. Boundary crossings that happen unintentionally but land hard anyway. The mother who feels like a guest in her own home. The grandmother who takes over

without being asked. The family dynamic that makes saying 'please do not do that' feel impossible.

Both of these things can be true at the same time. And that is the paradox.

The 'This Is How We Did It' Problem

Every generation has done it differently. Mustard oil massages. The baby sleeping face down. Kajal on newborn eyes. Gripe water from day one. These practices were common and accepted in earlier generations. Some of them are now understood to carry risks. Others are simply different from current medical guidance.

When an in - law insists on a practice that the parents are not comfortable with, here are some ways to navigate it:

- That is a really beautiful tradition. Let us ask the doctor about it at our next appointment.
- We are following our paediatrician's guidance for now - we want to be consistent.
- We appreciate everything you are doing. This particular thing we would like to handle differently.

You do not have to be confrontational. You do not have to explain at length. A clear, calm, kind statement is enough.

When They Move In - Setting Up a Loving Structure

If in - laws are staying for the first month or more - which is a common and often wonderful arrangement - it helps enormously to have a quiet, loving conversation early about who does what. Below are few examples:

Area	Who Handles It
Cooking & meals	Who is responsible, what the mother needs to eat
Grocery & errands	Who does the shopping and outside tasks
Medical decisions	Who accompanies parents to paediatrician appointments

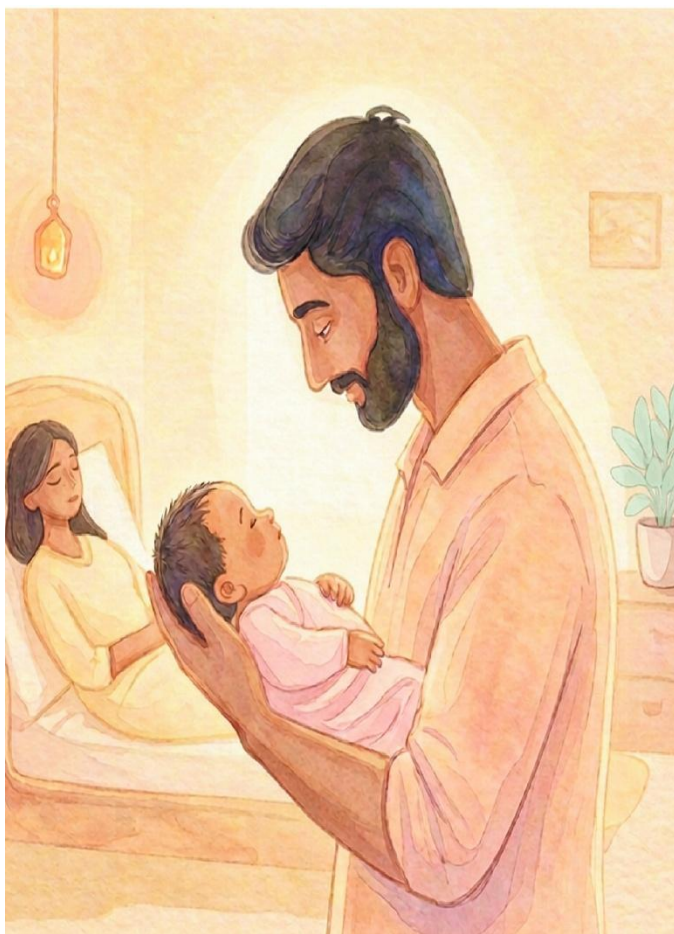
A Direct Note to In - Laws Reading This

Your presence is one of the greatest gifts you can give this family. Your cooking, your help, your love - these things matter more than you know. The small thing we are asking for is your awareness. Follow the parents' lead on medical decisions. Ask before you do things involving the baby. Remember that the new mother is recovering and needs support, not management. And know that when you show up with that kind of awareness, you will be remembered with so much love.

Mama's Hot Take

One thing that I communicated clearly was the change in my eating routine. After breastfeeding session, I used to get extremely extremely hungry, sometimes famished. I could not wait for the family dinner time. So, I ate whenever I was hungry. Sometimes I ate before everyone else, and sometimes afterwards. My meals were completely on demand.. And it helped enormously to keep my strength as well as my sanity.

Chapter 10: For The Partner



For the Partner: She Cannot Do This Alone. And She Should Not Have To.

If you are reading this, you are already doing better than most. Because most partners hand this book to their wife and walk away. You stayed. This chapter is for you.

Your partner just grew a human being inside her body for nine months, pushed or had that human surgically removed, and is now keeping them alive on no sleep and sheer love. The least - the very least - you can do is answer the door.

What She Is Going Through Right Now

- This is not an exaggeration. This is what the postpartum body and mind are dealing with simultaneously:
- Physical recovery from birth - whether vaginal or caesarean. Pain that is real, significant, and often invisible to everyone around her.
- Establishing breastfeeding, which is one of the hardest things many women ever do physically. Cracked nipples, engorgement, latch issues, supply anxiety - all while someone depends on her body every two hours.
- Hormonal fluctuations that are among the most dramatic the human body experiences. Up to 80% of new mothers experience the

'baby blues' in the first two weeks. I did not want to eat, I just wanted to be left alone. I experienced sudden urge to cry. My mom urging me to have food or my husband checking in to make sure I had eaten something made it worse. But thankfully, that phase went sooner.

- Sleep deprivation that is clinically significant. Not 'tired' - sleep - deprived in a way that affects cognitive function, emotional regulation, and physical healing. I remember I could not tell which day it was. Was it a Wednesday or a Friday. Same with dates. Sometimes I selected the wrong address for ordering, which I realized when I got the call from my family 😊

The weight of new identity. She is someone's mother now. The enormity of that does not have words.

Your Most Important Job: Gatekeeper

During the postpartum period, your single most important role is gatekeeper. This means that you - not her - manage the visitors. You communicate the rules. You respond to messages from the family group chat. You set the visiting hours. You end the visits when it is time. You say no when it needs to be said.

Your partner should never have to be the one to ask visitors to leave. She should never have to be the one

to tell your mother that now is not a good time. That is your job. Do it.

Things That Are Your Job - Non - Negotiable

- If a visitor overstays - it is YOUR job to end the visit. Not hers.
- If a relative gives advice that contradicts the doctor - it is YOUR job to redirect. Not hers.
- If someone wants to visit and the timing is not right - it is YOUR job to say so. Not hers.
- If she says she is fine - ask again. She is probably not fine.

The Partner's Daily Check - In

Every day, in an interval of 4 hours, ask yourself these questions:

1. Did she eat today? The meals, plus snacks?
2. Did she drink enough water?
3. Did she sleep? Did she get any uninterrupted rest?
4. Did she shower today?
5. Did I take the baby for at least one hour so she could breathe?
6. Did I manage all visitor communication today?
7. Did I ask how she is really doing - and actually listen?

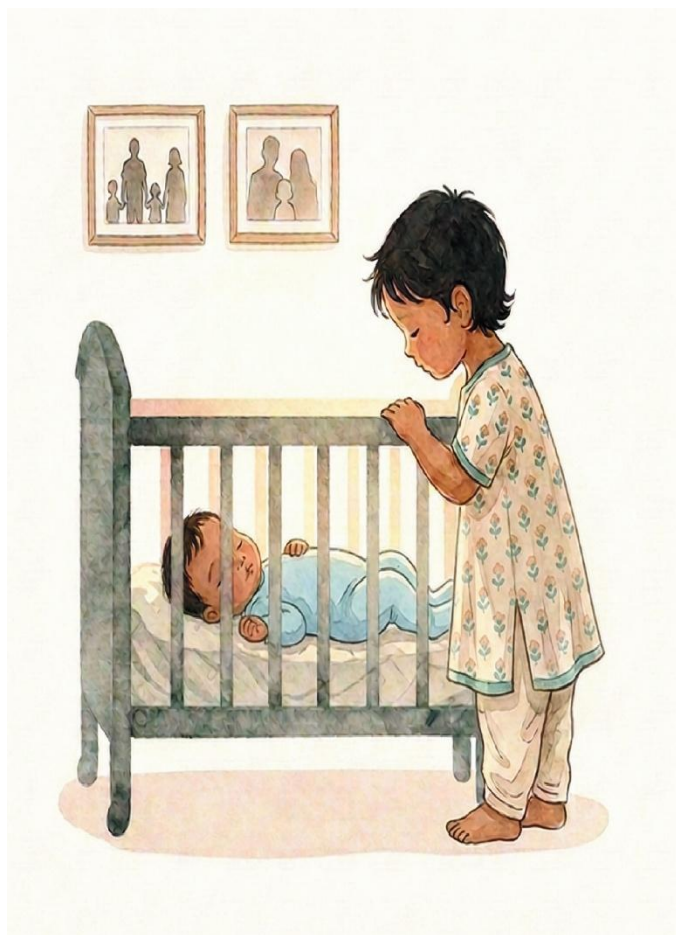
8. Did I do one kind thing for her today, just for her, not for the baby?

You do not have to be perfect. You just have to show up. Every single day. That is everything.

Mama's Hot Take

"The thing I needed most from my partner was not grand gestures. He answered the door when visitors arrived. He made sure my water bottle was always filled and within my reach. Sometimes he would simply check in on me, give me a hug, or put a blanket over me. He managed the visitors so I didn't have to. They were small acts, but they meant everything."

Chapter 11: The Elder One



Don't Forget the Elder One: There Is a Little Heart Breaking Quietly in the Corner

Every room in the house is decorated for the baby. Every conversation is about the baby. Every gift is for the baby. Every visitor walks in, scans the room, and asks 'Where is the baby?' And somewhere in the corner of that busy, noisy, love - filled house - there is a little person who used to be the centre of that universe. And nobody has noticed that they are not okay.

This chapter is for the elder one.

What the Elder One Is Feeling

Here is what child psychologists understand about sibling transitions: the arrival of a new baby is one of the most significant events in a young child's life. Their world, as they knew it, has changed entirely. Everything that was theirs - the undivided attention of their parents, the centre - of - the - world status, the established routine - has shifted.

They do not have the vocabulary to say: 'I feel displaced. I feel forgotten. I love this baby but I also resent this baby and I feel terrible about resenting them.' What they say instead is: they act out. They regress. They become clingy, or withdrawn, or defiant. This is not bad behaviour. This is grief.

How Visitors Make It Worse - Without Knowing

- Walking in and going straight to the baby without acknowledging the elder child.
- Showering the baby with gifts and giving the elder child nothing - or something token and dismissive.
- Saying 'You are the big one now - you have to be responsible.' This is a burden, not a compliment.
- Spending the entire visit cooing over the baby while the older child watches.
- Excluding the older child from conversations about the baby, as though they are not part of the family event.

How Visitors Can Make It Better

- When you arrive, greet the elder child first. Before you look for the baby.
- Ask the older child to introduce you to the baby. Give them a role. Give them ownership.
- Bring something for them - small, thoughtful, specifically for them.
- Spend time with them. Ask about their week. Ask about school. Show them that they still matter.

- Never say 'You are the big one now - be responsible.' Say instead: 'Being a big sibling is the most special thing in the world.'

What You Can Say to the Elder One

What to Say	Why It Helps
Tell me - what do YOU think of the baby?	Gives them agency and a voice in the conversation
I brought something just for you	Signals that they were thought of separately, not as an afterthought
Being a big sibling is the most important job in the world	Reframes their role as a privilege, not a loss
Can you show me the baby's room?	Involves them as the tour guide - their home, their knowledge
Your little sibling is so lucky to have you	Affirms their value in the family dynamic
Let's play your favourite game together	Gives them attention that is entirely theirs

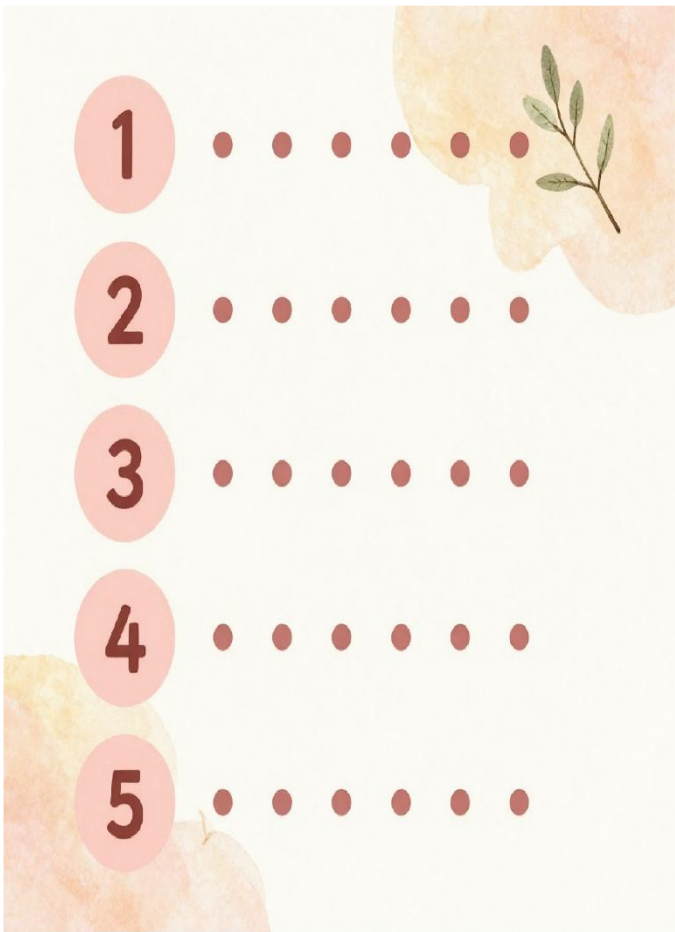
Mama's Hot Take

When our second one was born, we took ONLY our elder one to be the first to meet the little one. We wanted him to give some time before his world changes. My husband wanted to give him some time on his own to make sure that he knows that the baby

has arrived but he also had our attention. Only then, the grandparents came in.

Also, when the baby arrives, I started involving him with small tasks like “get me the diaper”, or “your task is to make sure people sanitise their hands before coming close to the baby” or “can you please get the wipes”. They feel they are seen; they are helping. And for them, that is all they need.

Chapter 12: 30 Things Every Visitor Must Know



30 Things Every Visitor Must Know Before Meeting a Newborn

Consider this as the master checklist. These are the thirty things that every visitor - grandparent, relative, friend, neighbour, colleague - should know before they step into a home with a newborn.

Before You Leave Your House (Pointers 1–5)

1. Always Call Before You Come. Never show up unannounced, no matter how close you are to the family. A message the day before is the minimum.
2. Check Your Health First. Even a mild cold, a slight cough, or 'just allergies' is reason enough to reschedule. A newborn's immune system cannot fight what yours can.
3. Wear Freshly Washed Clothes. Your outdoor clothes carry bacteria, allergens, and germs from every surface you have touched. Change before you visit.
4. Skip the Perfume and Cologne. Strong fragrances can irritate a newborn's sensitive respiratory system and overwhelm a new mother who may already be nauseous.
5. Confirm the Visit on the Morning of the day of the visit. Even if you planned it a week ago, confirm again in the morning. Babies do not

follow plans. The parents may have had a very rough night.

When You Arrive (Pointers 6–10)

6. Sanitise Your Hands at the Door. Before you touch anything, sanitise. Keep a 60%+ alcohol sanitiser in your bag always when visiting a newborn family. Generally, the newborn family would have it, but having it as a backup is also a good idea.
7. Take Off Your Shoes. Outdoor shoes bring in more germs than almost anything else. This should go without saying.
8. Speak Softly From the Moment You Enter. Lower your voice the second you walk in. A sleeping baby woken by excitement is nobody's friend.
9. Ask About the Mother First. Before you ask about the baby, turn to the mother and ask how she is doing. She just did something extraordinary.
10. Read the Room Immediately. If the mother looks exhausted and the house is quiet, this may not be a good time. Offer to come back. Genuinely.

Around the Baby (Pointers 11–20)

11. Sit Down Before Reaching for the Baby. Do not walk in and immediately reach for the newborn. Sit, settle, and wait to be invited.
12. Always Ask Before Holding. Even if you are the grandmother. Even if you are the closest friend. Always ask.
13. Support the Baby's Head at All Times. A newborn's neck muscles are not developed. One hand must always support the head.
14. Never Wake a Sleeping Baby for a Photo. A sleeping baby is a gift to exhausted parents. Do not unwrap it.
15. The Baby Is Not a Prop. Do not pass them around. Do not form a holding queue. If someone is already holding the baby, do not ask to go next.
16. Never Kiss the Baby - Anywhere. Not on the cheek, not on the forehead, not on the hands. This is a non - negotiable rule every time.
17. Keep Your Face Away From the Baby's Face. Even if you are healthy, breathing directly onto a newborn transfers germ. Keep a respectful distance.
18. Do Not Touch the Baby's Hands or Mouth. Newborns put their hands directly in their mouths. Your hands are a direct pathway for germs.

19. Keep Mobile Phones Away. Screens can overstimulate newborn eyes. Phone surfaces carry more bacteria than most people realise. Keep them away.
20. If the Baby Cries - Hand Them Back Immediately. Do not try to settle the baby yourself. Return them to the parent right away.

What You Say (Pointers 21–25)

21. Never Comment on the Baby's Skin Colour. Comments about complexion are inappropriate and hurtful. Full stop.
22. Never Express Gender Disappointment. Keep your opinions about the baby's gender entirely to yourself. There is no appropriate version of this comment.
23. Never Comment on the Baby's Weight. Whether the baby seems too small or too big - that is the paediatrician's job.
24. Never Give Unsolicited Parenting Advice. Unless you are asked, keep what worked for your baby to yourself.
25. Never Ask About Breastfeeding. Feeding is deeply personal and often medical. It is not your business.

During and After (Pointers 26–30)

26. Keep Your Visit to 30–40 Minutes Maximum. For the first two months, this is the rule.

27. Offer to Help - Do Not Just Sit There. Offer to fold laundry, hold the baby so mama can shower. Be useful.
28. Bring Food for the Mother. Homemade meals are priceless to a new mother.
29. Leave Before You Are Asked. Watch the body language. Leave when it is time to leave. Gracefully, without fuss.
30. Ask Before You Post Any Photos. Taking a photo does not give permission to share it. Always ask both parents before posting anything.

Quick Reference

Do's & Don'ts at a Glance

A master summary table - print this, share this, put it on the fridge.

DO ✓	DON'T ✗
Call ahead and confirm the visit	Show up unannounced
Keep visits to 30–40 minutes max	Overstay your welcome
Sanitise hands before entering	Touch the baby without sanitising
Wear freshly washed clothes	Come in outdoor clothes directly
Ask 'How are YOU doing?' to the mother	Focus only on the baby, ignore the mother
Speak gently and keep noise low	Make sudden loud sounds near the baby
Greet the older sibling first	Walk past them to get to the baby
Sit down before reaching for the baby	Immediately reach for the newborn
Ask permission before holding	Form a 'baby holding queue
Bring food for the mother	Sit as a guest expecting to be served
Get a gift for the older sibling too	Shower only the newborn with gifts
Respect the feeding and sleep schedule	Interrupt nap time or feeding time
Ask before taking photos	Post photos without consent

Leave when the mother looks tired	Wait to be asked to leave
Stay home if you have any illness	Visit with 'just a small cold'
Follow the parent's decisions	Override them with your own opinions

A Final Word

To every parent reading this - you are doing the most extraordinary thing. Growing a human being, birthing them, and now keeping them alive on no sleep and pure love. You deserve to be celebrated, protected, and supported. You deserve a village that shows up well.

I hope this book gives you the words you could not find. I hope it gives your visitors the awareness they were missing. I hope it gives your partner clarity amidst chaos. I hope it makes those early weeks feel just a little more manageable, a little less chaotic, and a little more filled with the right kind of love.

You are not failing. You are surviving. And that is everything.

To every visitor reading this - thank you. The fact that you are reading this at all means you love this family enough to show up better. That awareness is a gift in itself. You are already the kind of guest every new parent wishes for. Go be that for them.

A little awareness goes a very, very long way. One visit done well is worth ten visits done carelessly.

With love,

Puja Majumder

About Author

Puja Majumder is a mother of two, an author, and the woman who finally wrote down everything new parents wish they could say to their visitors - but couldn't, because they were too sleep-deprived to form sentences.

This book - Before You Visit The Baby - came out of a very real place. Two postpartum recoveries. Two rounds of well - meaning advice. Nobody was being cruel. But nobody had given them the memo either.

So, she wrote the memo.

Puja creates digital guides, printables, and resources for Indian parents navigating the chaos of the early years with a little more sanity and a lot more calm.

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